

“Script”

Billie Attig

Student Number: 73718058

Aboriginal & Treaty Rights

Law 353B.001

Professor: Jackson/Aldridge

April 29, 2008

The River & the Hunt:

The Métis people are a distinct group of people from mixed ancestry who settled in the Red River area during the fur trade. In the beginning, the mixed blood people did not live in separate communities as a separate people. They often lived with their Aboriginal relatives, working in the fur trade as middle men between the white corporations and the Aboriginal trappers. It was not until the Métis came together to fight back against the Hudson Bay Corporation (“HBC”) that they were galvanized as a separate and distinct group. From the Battle of 7 Oaks came stories, songs and an assertion of nationhood. As HBC began to lose interest in the fur trade and pulled its traders out of the west, the Métis people began settling in their own communities.

The Métis people were able to negotiate a settlement belt along the Red River with the Sioux people. The land was divided between the different Métis families as lots that began at the River extending away allowing each family access to the water and other resources that the river had to offer. Every season, the Métis would pack their belongings onto their carts and head off to the buffalo hunt. The hunt was the central form of social organization of the Métis.

As Canada sought to expand westward, the HBC sold Ruperts land to Canada, without considering the people who lived there (the Métis). Before Canada had acquired the land, they attempted to survey it, cutting the lots into traditional European squares without regard to the close relationship of the Métis families or access to the River. The Métis rebelled against the actions of Canada.

The seasonal buffalo hunt in addition to the increased number of squatters translated into Métis people returning from the hunt to find that their land had been reduced in size due to settlement or that it had been settled altogether. The Canadian government attempted to negotiate with the Métis by promising them pieces of land known as script. Those pieces ended up being smaller than what the new settlers were entitled to and they attempted to separate the family unit by providing grants to lands that were hundreds of miles away from the central family plot. As a result, many of the scripts were sold off to white settlers, who then resold them for an inflated price. In order for Métis people to ensure continuity of their families, communities and culture, they have had to choose but become a 'landless' people.

"Script" demonstrate the difference between the treaty the Métis people negotiated with the Sioux and the treaty that was handed down to the Métis by Canada. On the north side of the river, the grey lifeless plots have been divided up in the European tradition, dividing families and attempting to divide the Métis people. Not all of the lots have access to the resources that are required and some lots are off in the distance. By dividing the land in such a way, the Canadian government has attempted to divide the Métis people in order to conquer them. The result has been a break in tradition and culture within the Métis community. As a Métis person, I believe that the attempted destruction of the Métis community has led many Métis people to feel like a people without a home, straddling two nations, not belonging to either and not having a strong nation of their own.

The south side of the river expresses the life, warmth and energy that was the result of the treaty

the Métis were able to negotiate with the Sioux and how the Métis were then able to organize themselves by focusing on the family and the larger community. The division of land allowed each family a plot that had access to the River, ensuring that the entire community was cared for. The bright green expresses how the River was central to the life of the Métis settlement. Not only does the green invoke feeling of positive energy, it also represents how the River was necessary for life, both figuratively and literally speaking. The Métis style of land division is placed on the south side of the river to demonstrate the land's proximity to the river as opposed to the distance created by the Canadian land script.

The buffalo is the central figure in the piece as well as in Métis culture. The buffalo hunt was the other central organizational instrument of the Métis people, besides the river. The hunt provided food for survival as well as social organization, culture, tradition and law. Unfortunately, the buffalo hunt provided the opportune time for squatters to come onto Métis settlements and take up the land for agriculture. Upon the return of the Métis from the hunt, they discovered that they had been 'evicted' from their land base. In the piece, the buffalo is standing on the green side of the river as the hunt should not be blamed for the attempted disillusionment of the Red River settlement and the Métis as a distinct people, but rather the buffalo hunt should be viewed positively as the life line of the Métis people.

The Flower Bead Work People:

The Métis people combined their Aboriginal and European heritages to create a style of

beadwork that was unique. Once thought to be traditional designs of the Aboriginal people of the Northern forests, the floral motifs have are seldom present before the 1700's.¹ As the Métis settled into communities, missionaries were recruited to educate the children. Métis people were exposed to the French Grey Nuns through the mission schools. The Nuns passed on their tradition of flower silk embroidery which was transformed by the Métis women by incorporating the flower style into traditional Aboriginal porcupine quill work.² The result was a colourful, symmetrical floral design that was distinctive to the Métis beadwork. The Métis often traded their adorned clothing, bags and horse gear to travelers through “real Indians”.³

I have used a traditional style of beadwork in a more contemporary way. The central flower is a wild rose, often found in Métis beadwork designs. The flower sits in the center of the design, influencing the positioning and relationship of all of the flowers around it. The wild rose signifies the heart of the Métis people as the design of the flower expresses the beauty that can be found when two differing cultures can come together in unison. The wild rose is also a flower that is indigenous to the prairie region, where the Red River Settlement is located.

A vine grows out of the wild rose, spiraling outward from the centre. On the vine are several different types of flowers, also found in Métis beadwork. The vine and flowers are branching off of the central piece, always connected to its past but continue to transform and grow into the

¹<http://www.geocities.com/SoHo/Atrium/4832/art.html>

²<http://www.louiseinstitute.com/culture/art/php>

³*Ibid.*

future. The spiral design breaks away from the traditional symmetrical look of traditional Métis beadwork. The spiral signifies the reproduction of knowledge and learning, always being informed by what has been learnt in the past, but always looking to the future for positive change. The leaf at the tip of the spiral signifies that the learning process is always occurring and is never stagnant. Each flower on the vine has a relationship with the central flower. Several different types of flowers were used on the vine, signifying that there are many different ways of learning, each with its own value.

The brightly coloured beadwork piece is positioned against a brown background allowing the beauty of the design to be showcased. The flower design is placed on the buffalo to express how the buffalo hunt has informed the evolution of Métis culture and community.

Conclusion:

The blue sky represents the future. I hope that “Script” is interpreted as a positive, motivational piece for all Métis people to learn about their history so that we can take control of our future.